

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

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Jerusalem

Jerusalem was an active city as early as four hundred years before the time of King David. The Israelites never fully captured it when they conquered Canaan or during the time of the judges (Joshua 15:63; Judges 1:8, 21). Israel established peaceful relations with the independent area of the Jebusites (Judges 19:10-12). Jerusalem was so difficult to capture that the Old Testament mentions only three successful invaders: David, Jehoash, and Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon (2 Kings 14:11-14; 2 Kings 25:1-10).

King David captured Jerusalem, possibly through a water tunnel (see study note on 5:8). He made Jerusalem the political capital of Israel. Then later it became the spiritual capital. Psalm 48 gives a beautiful and powerful description of Jerusalem as a fortress. It had towers, walls (bulwarks), and easily defended heights (citadels) on rugged terrain. This could have deceived those living there with a false sense of security or even idolatry. Psalm 48:1-3 reminds readers that Jerusalem's landscape did not make it safe, but because God was present.

Both the Old Testament and the New Testament call Jerusalem a "holy city" (see Nehemiah 11:1, 18; Isaiah 52:1; Daniel 9:24; Matthew 4:5; 27:53; Revelation 21:2). It is the only city described this way in the Bible. Why is this city considered holy? It is certainly not because of the holiness of its people. In fact, the Babylonians destroyed the city in 586 BC because the people were so unholy.

It was also not holy because it was Israel's capital for many centuries. Jerusalem was a holy city because God chose it (1 Kings 8:44, 48; 11:13, 32, 36; 2 Chronicles 6:5, 34). Because he chose it, he placed his glory and his name there (see 1 Kings 14:21; 2 Chronicles 12:13; Ezekiel 8-10; 43:1-27).

In the gospels and book of Acts, Jerusalem remained very important. Herod the Great was king of Judea from 37-4 BC. He expanded the city of Jerusalem and led major building projects, including the temple. It was still the center of Israel's spiritual life (see, for example, Acts 2:46; 3:1-26; 5:12). Many events in the lives of Jesus and his followers happened in Jerusalem.

Jesus spoke harshly about Jerusalem (see Matthew 23:37-39). He was especially harsh towards its leaders. They eventually killed him in Jerusalem. Jesus warned that God would judge the city (see Mark 13:1-2; Luke

21:20-24). His words came true when the Romans destroyed Jerusalem in AD 70.

The New Testament also introduces "the new Jerusalem," a heavenly city formed by God's holy people (Hebrews 11:10; Revelation 3:12; 21:2). The earthly Jerusalem was where God and his rule were partly present through King David and his successors. The new Jerusalem represents the government of Jesus Christ, the final royal heir of David. The New Jerusalem also represents Jesus' eternal presence with his people (compare John 1:14; Revelation 21:3).

Passages for Further Study

Joshua 15:63; Judges 1:8, 21; 2 Samuel 5:6-9; 1 Kings 8:1; 2 Kings 18:13-17; 25:1-10; 2 Chronicles 3:1; 12:1-12; 26:9, 15; 32:1-5, 27-30; Ezra 1:1-6; Nehemiah 1:1-6:19; Psalm 48:1-3; 125:2; Isaiah 14:32; 52:1-3; Galatians 4:25-26; Hebrews 12:22-24

Jesus and Satan

Satan is a personal agent of sin and evil who opposed Jesus (Matthew 4:1-11).

The Gospel of Matthew refers to this being as:

- "Satan," which means adversary or opponent (4:10)
- the "devil" (4:1-11; 13:39)
- the "tempter" (4:3)
- the "prince of demons" (9:34)
- "Beelzebul" (12:24)
- the "evil one" (6:13; 13:19)
- "the enemy" (13:39)

Jesus' mission to announce and bring the kingdom of God on earth led to conflicts with Satan's forces. This included removing demons who possessed people (exorcism) (see Matthew 8:16-17; 9:32-34; 10:1, 7-8; 12:22-29; Mark 5:1-20). Matthew notes that Satan has power over kingdoms (Matthew 4:8-9; 12:26). He also commands angels (25:41).

Satan's main method of causing harm is temptation. His purpose is to make people disobey God (Matthew 4:1-11; 6:13; 16:23). As God's agent for human salvation, Jesus encountered strong attacks from Satan (Matthew 4:1-11; John 13:27). Yet, Jesus has defeated Satan and will eventually remove all his powers (Matthew 25:41; John 12:31; Revelation 20:1-10).

Passages for Further Study

Job 1:6-12; 2:1-7; Zechariah 3:1-2; Matthew 4:1-11; 13:19; 16:23; Luke 10:17-20; 13:16; 22:3, 31-32; John 12:31; 13:27; Acts 5:3; 26:17-18; 2 Corinthians 4:4; 11:13-14; 1 Timothy 2:14; 5:15; Revelation 12:9; 20:1-10

Jesus' Final Night

When Jesus went to Jerusalem to celebrate the feast of Passover, he knew it was his last night before death. He came to Jerusalem to “suffer many things and ... be killed” (Mark 8:31). His disciples prepared the meal, but he needed to prepare them for what was coming.

Jesus celebrated the Passover with his disciples. During this meal, he showed them what a true servant is by washing their feet (John 13:1–20). He gave them his final teachings, told them about the coming of the Holy Spirit, and prayed for his followers (John 14:1–17:26). Jesus also established the new covenant (Mark 14:22–24). Jesus replaced the Passover lamb. His body and blood became the sacrifice that saves God's people from judgment, just like the lamb at the first Passover.

During Passover, God killed all the firstborn males of the Egyptians but spared those of Israel. Now, Jesus would become the sacrifice to save his people. The prophets predicted this would happen (for example, Zechariah 12:10; 13:7). Jesus warned his disciples that this would soon happen and that they would abandon him (Mark 14:27). He also warned them that one of them would betray him (Mark 14:18).

After the meal, Jesus and his disciples walked to the garden of Gethsemane on the Mount of Olives. There, Jesus was deeply troubled as he prayed, accepting God's will (Mark 14:26–42).

Judas was the disciple who betrayed Jesus. He arrived with soldiers who arrested Jesus (Mark 14:43–49). Jesus' disciples ran away (Mark 14:50–52). Then they took Jesus to the high priest's house for a trial at night. During this time, Peter denied knowing Jesus three times (Mark 14:53–72).

Jesus already knew what would happen on his last night, the good and bad. It all happened according to God's plan. These events were necessary to fulfill what Scripture prophesied and for what followed. This included his death and resurrection.

Passages for Further Study

Matthew 26:17–56; Mark 14:12–52; Luke 22:7–46; John 13:1–18:11; 1 Corinthians 11:23–34

Jesus' Prayers

In Luke's gospel, Jesus prays during important moments in his life:

1. At his baptism (Luke 3:21).
2. Before choosing the twelve apostles (6:12).

3. At the transfiguration, when Jesus' appearance changed to reveal his glory (9:28–29).
4. On behalf of Peter before he denied Christ (22:32)
5. On behalf of those who killed him while he hung on the cross (23:34)

Sometimes, Jesus went away from others to pray alone (Matthew 14:23; Mark 1:35; Luke 5:16). He also taught the disciples how to pray (Luke 11:1–4; see also Matthew 6:5–13). He shared stories about the importance of constant prayer (Luke 11:5–13; 18:1–8).

In the Gospel of Luke, Jesus' prayers emphasize the intimate relationship between the Father and the Son. Jesus lived in harmony with his Father, followed his purpose, and remained faithful to his will.

In Gethsemane, Jesus was deeply troubled about the suffering to come. But he prayed, “not My will, but Yours be done” (Luke 22:42). On the cross, he showed complete trust in the Father. His last words were, “Father, into Your hands I commit My Spirit” (Luke 23:46). Jesus showed us how to live a life of trust and dependence on our heavenly Father.

The apostle John writes about a prayer Jesus said on his last night with the disciples (John 17:1–26). This is often called the “high priestly prayer.” In this prayer, Jesus prays to God on behalf of his followers. He asks God to protect them, help them understand, make them holy, and keep them united as one group.

Passages for Further Study

Matthew 6:9–13; Luke 3:21; 6:12; 9:28; 11:1–13; 18:1–8; 22:32, 39–46; 23:34, 46; John 17:1–26

Jews and Gentiles (Non-Jews)

A key theme of the New Testament is that God has included non-Jewish people (called gentiles) in his people while keeping his promises to Israel. In Romans 11:11–32, the apostle Paul explains God's plan to save all nations in four clearly defined stages:

1. The apostles share the good news about Jesus with the Jews. Most of them do not believe it.

Paul uses an olive tree as a metaphor. He says, “some branches have been broken off” (Romans 11:17). This stage had already happened and Paul personally experienced it. He shared the good news with Jews in their places of worship (synagogues) across the eastern Mediterranean region. But, many Jews rejected Paul's message (see Acts 13:42–49; 18:4–6; 28:23–28).

1. Many non-Jews accept the message and trust in Jesus.

After God removes the “natural branches,” he grafts in “a wild olive shoot” (Romans 11:17). Paul and the other apostles encountered resistance in the synagogues. So they preached to non-Jews, and many accepted the good news (see Acts 13:48–49; 26:15–18). By the time Paul wrote the letter to the Romans, the church in Rome was mostly a non-Jewish community.

1. Many Jews accept the good news and trust in Jesus.

As for the “natural branches,” God can “graft them again” (Romans 11:23). Paul argues that the Jews are not “beyond recovery” and can turn to Christ (11:11). Paul hopes that as non-Jews receive the blessings of salvation, Jews will feel inspired and respond to the good news (11:11–15).

1. God gives great blessings to the world, including the resurrection of the dead.

Paul suggests that when many Jews trust in Christ, it will greatly bless the world (Romans 11:12, 15). Those who accept God's offer of salvation, whether Jews or non-Jews, experience “life from the dead” (see 11:15). They will one day experience “the resurrection of the dead” (see 1 Corinthians 15:20–26). At the end of history, a large community of Jews and non-Jews will praise God for his mercy. Then everyone will see and understand God's great wisdom and love (Romans 11:33–36).

Passages for Further Study

Deuteronomy 7:7–8; 32:19–21; Isaiah 9:1–3; 49:6; Matthew 4:15–16; 8:10–12; 15:21–28; Luke 21:20–24; Acts 2:38–39; 10:45–46; 11:12–18; 13:42–49; 18:4–6; 26:15–18; 28:23–28; Romans 1:5–6, 16–17; 2:9–10, 24–27; 3:9, 29–30; 9:25–33; 10:11–13; 11:11–36; 15:7–13, 27; 1 Corinthians 12:13; Galatians 2:8–21; 3:8–9, 26–29; Ephesians 2:11–22; 3:6; Colossians 3:11

Job's Innocence

Job's comforters could not accept the idea that any human could be truly innocent (Job 4:17–19; 15:14–16; 25:4–6). They believed suffering was a direct result of sin. So, Job must have done something wrong to deserve his fate. Job's claim to innocence seems to contradict the biblical teaching that “there is no one righteous, not even one... all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God” (Romans 3:10, 23). Was Job correct in declaring his innocence?

Eliphaz and the others misunderstood Job's position. When they denied that Job could be right or pure, they were referring to the absolute difference between the Creator (God) and the creature (humans). But Job was not claiming to be completely pure. He admitted he had sinned when he was young (Job 13:26). And he

knew he needed God to forgive his sins and remove his guilt (14:16–17).

At the same time, Job often stated his honesty and his innocence in his relationship with God (Job 13:14–18; 23:10–12; 27:3–6; 31:1–40). Even Eliphaz admitted that Job lived an upright life (4:6). Job's faith led him to seek an audience with God, believing in God's justice despite his suffering. Job continued to hope for a Redeemer (19:25).

God's justice might require a mediator, and it might not be clear before death (Job 9:33–35; 19:26). But Job trusted that he would be proven innocent. He lived “by faith, not by sight” (2 Corinthians 5:7; see also Romans 8:24; 1 Corinthians 13:12; 2 Corinthians 4:18; Hebrews 11:1–2; 1 Peter 1:6–8).

When compared to the perfect righteousness of Jesus Christ, Job is a sinner like all of us. Job was not made right with God by his own deeds but by his faith in God. On that basis, God declared Job to be “blameless and upright, fearing God and shunning evil” (Job 1:1, 8; 2:3; 42:7–8). God does the same for us when we, like Job, put our complete trust in him (see Romans 4:4–5; James 2:23).

Passages for Further Study

1 Kings 8:46; Job 1:1, 8–11; 2:3–5; 4:6; 9:33–34; 13:18; 14:16–17; 15:14; 19:25–26; 23:10; 25:4; 27:5–6; 42:7–8; Psalms 25:7; 37:37; 51:17; Ezekiel 4:14; Romans 3:10, 23, 25; 4:4–5; 6:23; 1 Corinthians 13:12; 2 Corinthians 4:18

John's Profile of Discipleship

In the first half of his Gospel, the apostle John describes various people who show true discipleship (see John 1:19–51; 4:1–42; 9:1–41). Through these examples, John outlines the qualities of a mature follower, or “disciple,” of Jesus.

What are the qualities of a disciple?

1. Disciples know who Jesus is. In each of these three stories, they identify Jesus correctly (see, for example, John 1:34, 36, 38, 41; 4:19, 29, 31; 9:2, 17, 35–38).
2. Disciples trust in Jesus. They witness Jesus' powerful acts, listen to his wise words, and trust (see 1:49; 4:39–42; 9:35–38; see also 20:8, 24–29).
3. Jesus' disciples understand that they must follow him for their discipleship to succeed (1:37–43; 8:12; 10:4–5, 27; 12:26; 21:19–22). “Following” means true devotion, leaving what we have to join Jesus on his journey.

John shared this example of true discipleship to inspire readers to join these brave men and women and become disciples of Jesus too (see John 20:30–31).

Passages for Further Study

Matthew 9:9–10; 10:16–22; 16:24–28; Luke 14:26–33; John 8:31–32; 9:1–41; 12:25–26; 13:35; 18:36; Acts 9:2; Romans 15:5; 1 Corinthians 3:4–11